

Delphinus delphis

Short-beaked common dolphin



Length 5¼–7½ ft (1.6–2.3 m)
Weight 440 lb (Up to 200 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern

Location Temperate and tropical waters worldwide



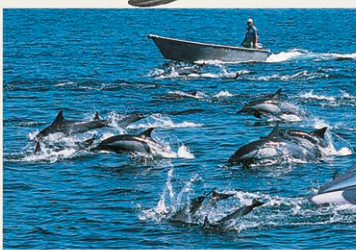
HOURLASS PATTERN

The flanks have yellow and creamy gray areas that form a distinctive hourglass shape.



SCHOOLING

Short-beaked common dolphins are very social, forming fast-swimming schools of thousands. They leap and tumble, ride waves from ships and great whales, and make many sounds such as clicks, squeaks, and creaks. Their whistles are loud enough to be heard from nearby boats.



This species has a yellow to buff blaze along the flank, from the face to below the dorsal fin. It tapers to a point, then widens again toward the tail, but as pale gray. There are also dark, narrow stripes from mouth corner to eye and chin to flipper. The short-beaked common dolphin has 41–52 pairs of small, sharp teeth in the upper jaw, and the same in the lower jaw. It lives offshore in the deep ocean; the inshore form is regarded as a separate species, *Delphinus capensis*, with 2 subspecies. Both species hunt schooling fish and squid to a depth of 985 ft (300 m).

Lissodelphis borealis

Northern right-whale dolphin



Length Up to 9¾ ft (3 m)
Weight Up to 250 lb (115 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern

Location North Pacific



This sociable dolphin forms schools of 100–200, which merge into gatherings of thousands. It makes varied sounds and associates with other cetaceans, leaping high and riding ship bow waves. Its main foods are midwater fish and squid, down to 655 ft (200 m). A similar species, *Lissodelphis peronii*, is found in southern oceans.

CONSERVATION

Due in part to its schooling habits, the northern right-whale dolphin is at high risk from drift nets set for fish and squid. In the 1980s, over 20,000 died every year. A UN moratorium on drift-netting has since slashed this figure, and bycatch losses have reduced due to acoustic warning systems.



SLIM AND FAST

The body is slender, with relatively small flippers and tail flukes, indicating that this dolphin is a speedy swimmer. It has no dorsal fin.



Orcaella brevirostris

Irrawaddy dolphin



Length 3½–4¼ ft (1.1–1.3 m)
Weight 200–330 lb (90–150 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Vulnerable

Location S.E. Asia and N. Australia

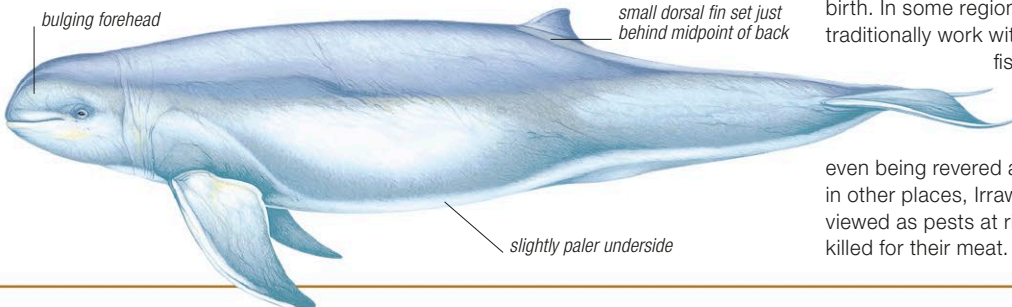


This river dolphin's distinctive features include a bulging forehead, no proper beak but ridgelike lips, and "creases" demarcating a neck region between

head and body. The head muscles allow a wide range of facial expressions, giving this dolphin an animated appearance to human observers; however, equating expressions to ours is extremely conjectural. Some Irrawaddy dolphins live solely in fresh

water, roaming almost 930 miles (1,500 km) inland in the major waterways of the Irrawaddy (Burma) and Mekong (Vietnam). But overall, this is an estuarine and coastal species frequenting muddy, silt-laden river mouths and deltas. It swims slowly,

usually in groups of 2–6, and up to 25. It feeds on fish, squid, octopus, prawns, and similar prey on or near the seabed, using its 8–19 pairs of teeth in the upper jaw and 11–18 pairs in the lower. Gestation is estimated at 14 months, and the single calf is about 39 in (100 cm) long and 26 lb (12 kg) at birth. In some regions, these dolphins traditionally work with people to herd fish into nets, receiving reward of food for their cooperation, and even being revered as sacred. However, in other places, Irrawaddy dolphins are viewed as pests at river fisheries or killed for their meat.



Cephalorhynchus commersonii

Commerson's dolphin



Length 6 ft (Up to 1.8 m)
Weight Up to 190 lb (86 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Data deficient

Location S. South America, Falkland Islands, Indian Ocean (Kerguelen Islands)



Commerson's dolphin has similar coloration to that of the killer whale. Its forehead slopes smoothly from the snout, merging with its stocky body. The newborn calf, 26–30 in (65–75 cm) long, is gray and becomes two-tone with age. The species forms schools of less than 10 that sometimes expand up to 100. It feeds on seabed dwellers, such as fish, crabs, starfish, and squid. There are 2 populations (probably subspecies), separated by more than 4,970 miles (8,000 km)—those around South America being 10–12 in (25–30 cm) shorter than those in the Indian Ocean.

Cephalorhynchus hectori

Hector's dolphin



Length 5¼ ft (Up to 1.6 m)
Weight Up to 140 lb (Up to 65 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Endangered

Location New Zealand



One of the smallest dolphins, this species is similar to a porpoise in outline, with a smoothly tapering snout and no distinct

beak or melon bulge. It is gray with black flippers, dorsal fin, and tail. The white underside extends a projection up each flank toward the tail. Active and sociable, it forms small schools of up to 5, and spends much time chasing, touching, flipper-slapping, and generally interacting with others. It feeds at various depths, mainly on fish and squid. As an inshore species, Hector's dolphin is at particular risk from entanglement in fishing nets and from pollution.

